

October 11, 2023
Memo

Gender is most obviously socially constructed in the sense that, as the West and Zimmerman reading described it, “focus on behavioral aspects” rather than any other aspect. Behavioral means that gender was formed by using ways people interact socially and in different social environments, therefore it was constructed solely based on stereotypes present in social interactions. “Gender” was created in order to separate people based on biological differences, much like “race” was created in order to separate people based on mainly geographical differences. Neither of these terms are preordained or have any natural meaning, rather they were both socially constructed in order to put some self-appointed group of people in power over another. Gender was originally designed to put the male sex in power over the female sex with the reasoning being biological differences just like one race was put in power over another because of geographical differences. This led to the gender associated with males to be correlated with social attributes like “masculinity” and “strength” while the gender associated with females correlated with attributes like “femininity” and “weakness.” It is because of this initial disparity in social description that even today people associated with the gender of women tend to have less opportunities or less social “power” than people of the gender of men because they were defined in gender to be of an inferior status. That is also why people not of the male correlated gender are consciously thought of as less powerful in social situations than other genders if no special circumstances are present. Additionally, since gender provides preordained stereotypes about a person in society, the only way a person can escape their gender constraints and still participate in society is if they take up another definition, which is also stereotyped by society as being misfitted because the term gender is not as much a definition of a person as it is a stereotype and perpetuation of inequality.

Question: The term “gender” is changing faster in society as compared to the term “race.” Will there be a moment when the term will fade from usage or will it always be ingrained in society as a definition of a group of people?